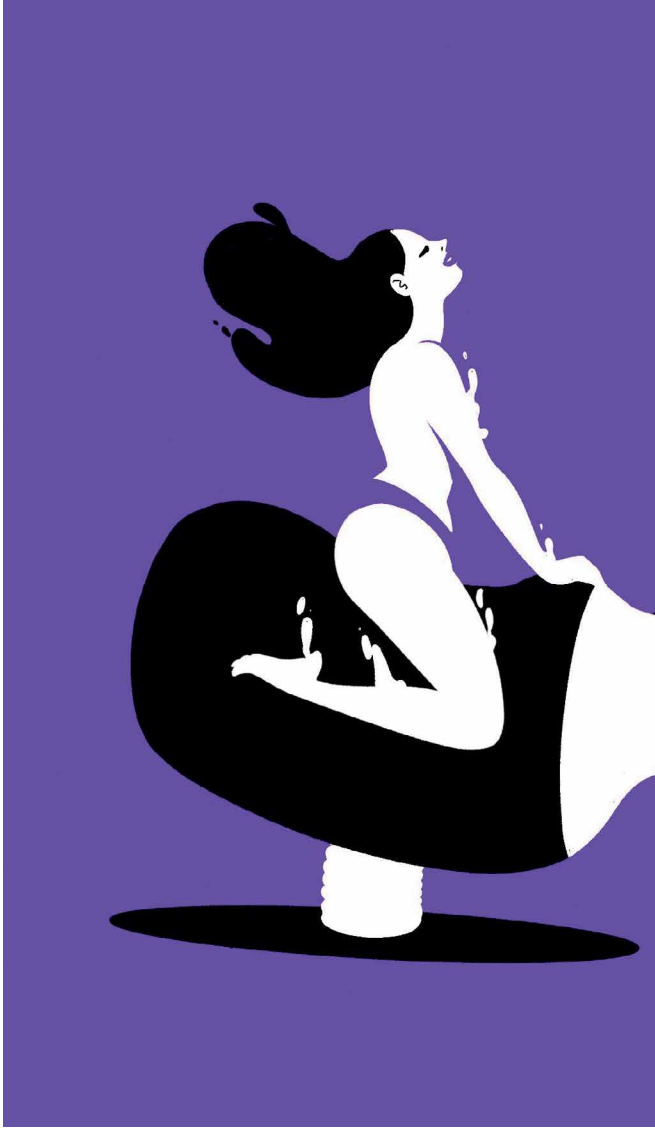
RIDING HIGH ON GADGETS



GIVE THEM A SHAPE, PACKAGE THEM WELL AND PAIR THEM WITH YOUR IMAGINATION... SEX TOYS CAN DELIVER THE MOST WONDERFUL EXPERIENCE

By **RAJ ARMANI**

"Have you gone totally crazy?"
"You will be behind bars in no time!"
"It is not only a crime, but also against our culture"
"You will be blacklisted..."

THESE ARE SOME OF THE NICEST COMMENTS I HAD THE pleasure of receiving when people came to know we were about to launch India's first adult store (a nicer way of saying 'sex shop'), but that was 2012. It has been almost 10 years since we have been live. As of October 2022, we have delivered to over a million customers in India and welcome 4-5 million visitors to our website annually from various sections of society: celebrities, politicians, sportspeople, the rich and famous, middle class, and even people whom we know in our network... who quietly place orders praying hard that we won't find out. Well, we do, but our lips are sealed because we promise 100 per cent privacy to each and every customer who shops with us.

And so far, we haven't been put behind bars. But I did get myself on the front page of a newspaper (side by side with the Mumbai police commissioner) as I became the face of a 'new-age India'—all by selling sex toys online. Give them a shape, package them well and pair them with your imagination, and they can deliver the most awesome experience. In my opinion, they are crucial aids to happiness. But, alas, a majority of our population does not think that way. There are many challenges in working in India's sex economy—your nosy Pammi aunty is the least of which.

The real challenges we have faced have evolved over the years. In the early days, it was about restrictions in reaching out to the masses. Though we signed Sunny Leone to be the face of our brand and started out with a robust budget for marketing, the social media would find our brand too outrageous and restrictions imposed on Google by Indian laws limited our reach. Even though we had built a healthy pool of customers, we couldn't get enough word-of-mouth—because '*log kya kahenge*' (what would the people say)? We tried to put up billboards, but the deal fell through at the last minute because the legal department freaked out.

When we managed to improve our reach through organic growth, we encountered newer challenges around imports and often had tiffs with the Customs. They fondly called us the 'Playboy of India' and then shut down two of our warehouses, taking away almost $200,000 worth of merchandise. We tried to stick to our guns, asking how a hairbrush with a vibrating handle could be a sex toy

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE